

Underground water

Much of the rain that falls from the sky sinks into the ground. Some is immediately soaked up by plants, while some seeps down into porous (water-holding) rocks. It flows gradually downhill beneath the ground, where it forms natural reservoirs that we can access by digging wells. The water can also reappear at springs or in temporary lakes.



THE WATER TABLE

Rainwater drains through soil, sand, and porous rock until it reaches a layer of impermeable (waterproof) rock such as granite. This stops it from sinking any farther, so the ground above fills with water like a bucket of wet sand. The top of this saturated zone is called the water table. If you dig deep enough to pass this point, the bottom of the hole fills with water to form a well.

◀ DEEP WELL

A bucket lowered down a well brings cool, fresh water to the surface.

CHANGING LEVELS

In a wet season, the level of the water table on low-lying land can be very close to the surface, saturating the soil and creating a marsh or swamp. If the rain keeps falling, the water table rises above ground level, causing the land to flood. In a drought, the water table can sink so far below ground that lakes and rivers dry up, leaving dry, cracked earth.

FACT!

Dragon's Breath Cave in Namibia contains the largest underground lake in the world. It lies about 330 ft (100 m) below the surface, and covers 5 acres (2 hectares).